NET GOOD

Pilot - "The Long String"

by

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INT. MARITIME BOARD - DAY

Distant chugging and caws of seagulls blend through the impatient chatter of civil servants in the Maritime Board's narrow and two-tiered office. Though the classroom-style desks are pushed to the side, and chairs laid out in rows for a presentation, many lean over the back of their chairs in conversation.

Memos and water damage on the vertical-planked walls, cables managed through mounted shark jaws, desks with wooden groynes for legs... This office is a slice of bureaucracy that must be nestled right between the tight boardwalks of a docks, even suspended above water itself.

Everything rattles - the door bursts open. In pounces POSEY, mid 40s web designer, a floppy disk between her teeth and aiming an oversized handheld weapon at the room. A briefcase also dangles from her two-handed grip on the weapon.

Light-brown skin and chin-length black frizzy hair. She wears high-waisted and square cut trousers, checked blazer over a tucked-in oversized t-shirt with colourful logo: "Get Online!". She speaks in an international school American English that's proudly subsumed much of the local accent from decades living here.

POSEY
(through the disk)
Everybody on the ground!

A handful of unentertained pencil pushers turn to look at the door. Their wardrobe blends imperial naval uniform with late-century office-grey suits and skirts. Many of the men sport long beards. Nobody gets on the ground. Nobody laughs. Slowly they resume their conversations, and Posey takes the disk out her mouth.

POSEY
Fine.

She casually shoots out a t-shirt, revealing her weapon as only a T-SHIRT CANNON and her entrance as a desperate jape. She joins two men by the projector. Someone unrolls her fired t-shirt with the slogan: "BIAS - Believe I'm A Surfer."

While Posey and CHRISTIAN, her late 40s Maritime Board contact, talk around a computer. RHYS, early 20s coder in Posey's team, keeps the front row entertained.

RHYS
So, many people know you can detach a thumb laterally. Not so many the rare perpendicular

thumb trick.

POSEY
(to Christian)
How can it not do them? The floppy disk has only been around since I was a kid. No, no. I have a spare.

Posey pointedly pulls out a floppy drive from her briefcase and plugs it in. With a thump and a whirr, the disk loads and she heads over to Rhys. She double takes at his thumb trick and shoots him with the t-shirt cannon.

RHYS
Jam sandwich, Posey!

POSEY
(Raising her voice)
Okay. Okay. Everyone found their seats? You'll want a front row one, but don't get jealous now.

The audience settle down. She presses a button on her remote with self-satisfied raised eyebrows, and a presentation starts behind her.

The slide: Three large letters above the curvature of the Earth in space - “SEO”.

POSEY
SEO. What is SEO? Other than the first three letters of the city I was born in... What is it? What is SEO?

Nobody reacts. Someone scratches their beard.

RHYS
Search Engine Optimisation.

POSEY
That’s right Rhys. Search Engine Optimisation. Well done Rhys.

The slide: People bobbing for apples.

POSEY(CONT'D)
It’s all to do with how soon you show up on different searches. These apple bobbers represent people using the internet. The apples they’re bobbing, that’s your website. The water is all the other crap. The bucket, their favourite search engine. The blindfold- Well...

Posey hurriedly flicks through the apple bobbing image as it becomes increasingly annotated.

The next slide: Many images. A smiling fishmonger, people trading at a market stall, clipart of someone using a magnifying glass.

POSEY
You want people to buy your muffins at your little mom-and-pop shop? That's an SEO sitch. People need to see your charity for miserable children before a charity for simply sad ones? That's a SEO sitch.
Rhys tells me there's some sort of line redrawing going on here at the Maritime Board, right? That's a SEO sitch! ...uation, you follow?
What's no sweat off your back could well be the difference between you popping up first...
(now in character)
or a conspiracy forum. About how you're shuffling poor fishermen around, you line-drawers! Got your fingers deep in the herring pie, huh?

Rhys gestures for her to move on.

POSEY(CONT'D)
Now the reason we're here is just to let you know what's going on when our copywriters come around and ask and awful lot of questions, getting to know all there is about the uh-

CHRISTIAN
The boundary shift.

POSEY
The boundary shift. Hey that's sort of dramatic. But probably quite boring. So moving on.

Posey very quickly flicks through a slide with a protractor-focused logo: "Centre for Steep Research." And then to a bar chart.

POSEY
Whoops! Okay so. Here's a chart demonstrating reach. Very small bar. Medium sort of bar. Very tall bar. Can you guess which bar we are? Anyone? The internet

bar.

EMPLOYEE
The very tall bar?

POSEY
Yes. You win a free shirt.

Posey shoots her cannon and hits a five-foot anchor on the wall that crashes down to the ground. Many gasp.

POSEY(CONT'D)
Wow! Who put that there?

CHRISTIAN
I did. Don't worry. Don't worry. Easily fixed.

POSEY
So... now that you're intimately familiar with the net, it's time for the net to become intimately familiar with you!

Christian leads a clap then puts a hand on Posey's shoulder.

CHRISTIAN
(To everyone)
Wow. Wow wow. So a real online presence for us. And these guys are great. I know these guys well from ten years ago or so. And the presentation too it seems, haha.

Posey screws her face up at Christian's comment.

INT. SHALLOW BUILDING CORRIDOR - DAY

FAUSTINE, mid 30s copywriter on Posey's team, meets Posey and Rhys coming the other way.

RHYS
Faustine.

FAUSTINE
How did it go? Make a splash?

RHYS
It did sort of... crash to the ground.

FAUSTINE
And you weighed the screen down this time? After Steep Research I thought- No, but listen I

have-

POSEY
Steep Research, my God! How, just how haven't we changed it by now? I mean ten years like that.

RHYS
(to Faustine)
She means some of the slides were the same.
(to Posey)
But Steep Research was only last month.

POSEY
No no no. The whole thing. I've been shifting the slides around, rewording titles, and changing logos since you were sucking your thumb-drive Rhys.

RHYS
That's disgusting.

POSEY
Well that's when it was I last did work with Christian. It's a Theseus's presentation of embarrassment. A past-ation! When it should be a yet-to-come-ation.

FAUSTINE
I thought a little retro was our thing. Posey, I really should-

POSEY
A little- I'm sorry that's just out the other ear, Faustine. We're supposed to be medias res!

As they walk down the corridor they pass enlarged magazine covers:

A shower of thin strips of paper in front of a Manhattan building and American flag - "Shallow Corporation Prints More Ticker Tape than Nazis Can Reasonably Burn."

Man whistling and pushing a snow plough piloted with an electric typewriter - "The Shallow Word-Processor Will Rescue You from the Paperwork Avalanche."

In the near corner of a boxing ring, an exhausted boxer sitting down while his coach sharpens his pencil. In the far corner the silhouette of a

computer tower - “Shallow Supercomputer Beats Grand Master in the Boxes Ring.”

FAUSTINE
But there’s something else-

POSEY
And I just can’t- I mean, so much do this week. I’ll get the rest of the weavers started right away.

FAUSTINE
Not right away.

Posey opens the door to not her team, but an office of strangers who look straight to her. Faustine deflates. Posey sighs, strides past the turning heads, past a man scraping out her name from a room divider...

“POSEY ‘THE PICKER-UPPER’ AHN - HEAD OF WEB DE-”

...to a rectangular outline on the opposite wall. She looks to a nearby bin, where she pulls out a picture frame and holds it to her chest.

POSEY
Where have we been plonked this time?

Everyone in the office and Faustine point upwards.

EXT. SHALLOW BUILDING ROOF - DAY

The sun is setting over a panoramic view of ABBEY-ON-SEA. On the South coast, the city sprawls around a bay which looks out onto the Flipping Channel that’s between there and the opposing peninsula. A few tall, curved buildings in mint and white give the city what could be called a skyline.

In the foreground, a hatch opens upwards on the concrete roof. Posey pops her head out then braces against a growing wind, heading towards an aerialed wooden hut. As she steps up onto the hut’s oddly shaped foundation, Faustine and Rhys admire the view behind her.

INT. NET LOFT - NIGHT

Inside the roughly five-by-eight metre hut, the seven other members of Posey’s team, affectionately called WEAVERS, unpack cardboard boxes, plug in computers and righten furniture. A couple of heads turn to her and then back to their tasks.

Posey nods to herself. She finds a patch of empty wall and hangs her framed magazine cover. The cover has a picture of teenage-posey leaning on a printer:

32-bit Pickup: how a young stenographer prevented the paper jam of the century at Shallow Corp.

Walking across weathered floorboards, Posey passes CARNEY, late 20s, confusedly looking at papers in a box labelled PALMPRINT.

CARNEY
Pass this onto Dina? It should not be in this box. OK?

Posey looks at the sheet of paper and then to the box.

POSEY
What? Hand Holdings? Oh well who can blame me, they're practically synonymous.

CARNEY
And don't let them hear that. OK?

Posey creaks over to DINA, who's lifting a desk. She holds the paper to Dina's face. Dina reluctantly nods her eyebrows.

POSEY
Here comes the aeroplane.

Dina takes the paper in her teeth and Posey wanders on through a cobweb. She accidently kicks a domed lampshade on the ground, picks it up, and finds with her eyes a lightbulb dangling from a rafter above a table in the corner.

POSEY
Anyone good with heights? Rhys?

Nobody around hears her. Deciding to do it herself, she climbs on the table and wobbles. When she rights herself, she stands up and is distracted by a higher view of the hut. Abandoning her task, she uses the lampshade as a megaphone.

POSEY
Hey. Hey. Attention.

Posey lowers her megaphone. The weavers slowly take seats, where they can find them. Posey looks around for inspiration.

POSEY
I Christen this the new and improved Net Loft.

She pulls up the dangling lightbulb like it's a bottle of champagne and lets it swing. There are a couple chuckles and Faustine rubs her hand into her own cheek. Posey

points out the view.

POSEY
Loftier than ever, might I add. But I know, you're wondering how the Maritime Board presentation went. Yes, I messed up the logos. Yes, a five-foot anchor crashed to the ground. They may be maritime, but they certainly weren't bored!

A groan.

POSEY
This last year or so has been... defining. And our work has been... international. We had it all in front of us.
(beat)
But we were jenga'd.

Posey mimes taking a block out a tower and putting it on the top.

POSEY
I'm actually very excited and anxious. And proud because we are now the aerial of this company. There's something that each of you understands up here that was and is reliably ten years ahead of any writetyper you just passed on the way up. We're the ones weaving the net. It's strong and it's good and it's right now.
(a beat)
Well right now, right now's this week. And this week is gonna be our week, you know. And it's got to be our week.

While she talks, her tone is punctuated by the battering of the flimsy windows from the gale outside. Posey looks around.

POSEY
I mean we are on top of the world.

Very suddenly, her face is illuminated by a flash of light. She covers her eyes with the lampshade, then, when the light passes, tips it up like the brim of a hat to look out the window. Past the city below, and just visible over a distinctive cliff is a glint of light. Posey looks confused, but when the light comes back around, she realises the weavers are anticipating her

conclusion.

POSEY
(shaken)
Here's to going up another floor, eh?

Behind her captive audience, a window breaks in from a strong gust of wind.

EXT. FLINT STREET - DAY

When driving, Posey pulls up at lights. Looking around she double takes at the distinctive cliff she can see down the right turn. She hops up in her seat as if she might suddenly see the gleam again behind it. But she doesn't have the same vantage from ground level. Posey shakes her head. And again. Finally she gives into her impulses and turns on her indicator, taking the turn away from the Shallow Building to investigate.

EXT. WOOLLY NESS - DAY

Posey's car rolls around a steep incline, revealing a solitary blue-and-white-striped lighthouse and rickety stilted wooden aqueduct going over the road from inland. As she drives under, a dribble of water lands on the windscreen and Posey turns on the wipers.

Getting out, she looks up at where the aqueduct connects to the tower four metres off the ground. She looks all the way up to where a flash from the spinning beacon confirms that WOOLLY NESS LIGHTHOUSE is the gleam she saw.

Posey wanders around to the other side facing out to sea. The lighthouse is on a cylindrical windowed concrete foundation half built into the cliff, and its tower has large vertical section cut out for a similarly four-metre-tall water wheel. Following the flow of water back out the tower, the rotating wheel is half inside, half outside. The water continues across the concrete foundation as an outlet, off the edge, and into the sea.

Posey continues circling the lighthouse anticlockwise, hopping over the outlet and around to a front door. Staring at the door, Posey's face goes in and out of sunlight peaking though the wheel. Then something falls beside her. She looks down at a work glove and up at someone navigating the lighthouse above her in a bosun's chair that dangles from the gallery and can rotate fully around the outside of the tower.

PALOMAR, late 50s lighthouse keeper, wears dungarees and a blue beanie. She's very large, tall and well-built. Posey steps out from the shadow of the waterwheel and

into Palamar's.

POSEY
You dropped something.

PALOMAR
That I did.

Posey raises her eyebrows and nods.

POSEY
You're the keeper then. Lighthouses have keepers I know that much, and if you weren't you could have said "So I did".

PALOMAR
That I am. Welcome to Woolly Ness.

Palomar removes her other glove with her teeth.

POSEY
Aren't you scared of rope burn?

PALOMAR
Scared, no. I've had enough rope burn in my day. And it doesn't do well to be scared of your own feet. Can't run away from 'em.

POSEY
(to herself)
Damn.
(to Palomar)
What am I keeping you from, keeper?

PALOMAR
Now I don't claim to be an artist, but I like to keep the blue blue and the white white. Down low!

She puts her keys in her other glove, drops them both.

PALOMAR(CONT'D)
Too slow.

Posey walks over.

POSEY
More of a picker-upper.

PALOMAR
Well. Seeing as I can't meet you at the bottom, you'll just have

to meet me at the top.

Posey shakes the keys out the glove.

POSEY
Ha, I guess I will then.

PALOMAR
Make it a race as well?

Posey puts the keys in the door and turns them.

POSEY
Ah. What the hell.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE - DAY

Posey steps inside.

In front of her is the other half of the waterwheel. Water flows in from the aqueduct, tumbles down the middle of the large ground floor of the tower, turning the wheel, then flows under it out the other side. She looks to her left, where a staircase follows the curve of the inside wall down into the basement. She hears a tap to her right, where Palomar opens one of many portholes flanking a similar staircase up.

PALOMAR
This way!

Posey shakes her head and starts jogging up the stairs. Palomar talks to her through the portholes, as she swings by on her chair.

PALOMAR
Keep a good count of those steps, by the way. In 1811, local Quaker Fredrick Weiss carved each one with a baking tray.

If you're wondering why these windows suddenly become square, it's because this whole section was taken out in the Blitz.

POSEY
(panting)
I don't suppose they built a square lift too. I'm not what I was. I'm not what I was.

EXT. LIGHTHOUSE GALLERY - DAY

Posey gets to the top out of breath.

POSEY
Ha! I win! Less of a walk and talk; more of a climb and lecture!

Looking around she sees Palomar tapping a commemorative plaque.

PALOMAR
This baking tray.

POSEY
Damn.

Posey regains her breath and some of her impassiveness as she reads the tray-turned-plaque:

POSEY
On this, the Seventeenth of October 1811, the beacon at Woolly Ness is first lit. Let its wall be home to many keepers and its gleam the lustre to many hulls. And in the eleventh hour, let its turning eclipse that of the minute hand.

She hands Palomar the glove and keys.

POSEY
You win. Thanks for the history lesson.

She smiles then turns to leave.

PALOMAR
That wasn't the tour you know. That was just a bit of scene setting.

POSEY
That's alright I didn't sign up for any tour.

PALOMAR
Not this one?

She reaches over and hands her a charming colour pencil poster: "Tours of the lighthouse every day. And a special haunted tour for Halloween on the 12th."

POSEY
Not me, not no one. This is what you fold up and squidge under a wobbly table.

Palomar bites her lip and leans on the railing.

PALOMAR
You know some people might admire the view.

Posey points at the commemorative tray and then the beacon.

POSEY
That's this is it?

Palomar nods. Posey whistles.

POSEY
One thousand years old...

Posey and Palomar slowly wander around the beacon.

PALOMAR
No... Two hundred. But it's a real Theseus's lantern, this. Like this Fresnel lens wasn't even invented in Weiss's time. So just torch-passing really.

That Palomar brought up Theseus too isn't lost on Posey. She squints then points at the emerging tip of the Shallow building.

POSEY
That's me. You weren't such a problem on the lower floors.
(a sigh)
One thousand years old and I almost thought of asking you to switch it off.

Posey fastens her gaze at the Net Loft in slight confusion. Palomar sees this and resigns to her company.

PALOMAR
I'll make you tea.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE BASEMENT - DAY

Posey looks out the window and her face is distorted by the stream of water.

POSEY
And how often does the dervish whirl?

Palomar brings over the tea.

PALOMAR
Once every twelve seconds.

POSEY

(into her tea)
Twelve seconds, wow.

She sits down on a sofa, and Palomar sits opposite painting a wooden sign.

POSEY
You didn't tell me your name.

Palomar turns around the sign, which has a row of coat hooks: Palomar.

POSEY
Pa-LO-ma?

PALOMAR
PA-lomar.

POSEY
Mm. A man, a plan, a...
(after a brief look up)
...fresnel?

PALOMAR
So the picker-upper picked it up. And who's she?

POSEY
Josephine Ahn. They call me Posey.

PALOMAR
Claro! Because you bend easily.

POSEY
Because I'm precious like a flower, surely? I do dot-com.

Palomar raises her eyebrows but doesn't look up.

POSEY
What?

PALOMAR
Nothing. Just thought I remembered something like that bursting.

POSEY
Oh could people stop saying that!

PALOMAR
(shrugging)
You asked.

POSEY
Right and your stack of junk

mail, what's the story there?

Palomar sighs and stares for several seconds.

PALOMAR
When I was young and stupid I spent the summer at a sleepaway camp, and we took a day trip to this lighthouse. Me and some friends snuck off and hid amongst the nooks and crannies. As we heard the yelling of our team leader to come out, one-by-one my friends did as they were told. I stayed for three nights here on my own.
The living situation for most of my life wasn't great and when I finally got out of it not too long ago, this was the only other home I'd known. I talked long and hard with the Historical Society about what could be done, and something must have come out then in what I said or how I said it that doesn't always come out.

POSEY
Well that is a story.

PALOMAR
You asked me what I was doing with that blue paint. They gave me a grant to fix up this place, but more importantly to increase its cultural significance and awareness through tours. And in my grand total of one tour it all became worth it to me when a boy asked me where the toilet was.

POSEY
Palomar that is a very low bar.

PALOMAR
That toilet was one of the first things I had replaced when I moved in, and I never let anyone else use it. But the look on his face was one I'd never quite seen before and I think some of my weaknesses come through in these tours, so I told him where it was.
When he came out again, he looked extraordinarily proud. He

confided in me that he always wanted to be a lighthouse keeper but needed to get over his singular fear. Revolving toilets.

POSEY
What? You're serious?

Palomar nods.

PALOMAR
I don't know how he believed these places were laid out, but to see someone now with no apprehensions of what lays ahead of them changed everything for me.
Before the family left, he drew a picture of me and the lighthouse and said I might use it for a flyer.

POSEY
Very charming. I did think.

PALOMAR
But I lost it and have never been able to draw something half as good. Tale told.

POSEY
Wow. I mean- I'm only sorry I have my life already figured out. I'd love to make it worth it for you all over again, heh.

PALOMAR
So will you trade me a story from your tower?

POSEY
Oh! A lot of the same, really. Directing kids to toilets, or rather- There was something. Yes, now I remember.
An old woman came to see me about a website. She was dying of one of the degenerative diseases and wanted all of her memories digitised. Well I made her this website, but when I went to ask for payment, and received no emails back I naturally assumed the worst. Finally when I did get a response, it was from her children and grandchildren. They

said that they were so moved and grateful and were more than happy to cover the cost. And while I can't be sure, it could well be the first digital epitaph we made with that one, which is a very touching thought.

Palomar looks her in the eyes.

PALOMAR
That's very commendable.

Posey bolts up, starts backing towards the stairs, awkwardly avoids some dangling shells.

POSEY
I should be going. Good luck with your grant. And um don't worry about turning the whole thing off on my account. I'll just remember to time my blinks right. Every twelve seconds, was it?

PALOMAR
Twelve seconds.

EXT. WOOLY NESS - NIGHT

Posey trudges back to the car. In the distance, the top of the Shallow Building is illuminated by the lighthouse. Posey follows the light around as distant hilltops are illuminated across the Flipping Channel, spinning in place all the while.

INT. NET LOFT — DAY

Posey sweeps broken glass into a dustpan below the broken window. Dina taps her on the shoulder.

DINA
How's this banner look for Hand Holdings?

POSEY
That's good. Hm. That's the one that shares a wall with a zoo, right? Never felt very safe to me, but maybe we could integrate that somehow.

DINA
You're a very confused person, Posey. That's Palmprint you're

thinking of. Though I could put the central business district into the logo if you'd like.

POSEY
Ooh. Better not.
(seeing Faustine)
Hey! Hey! Let's huddle about Maritime Board.

Faustine nods, and beckons over Rhys and a couple other weavers. Posey puts down the pan of glass, plugs in her laptop and carries it over to put on the chair next to hers so that the cable is suspended above the floor.

RHYS
We could definitely get to the top spot, SEO wise, if you can get those files ready by tomorrow morning Posey.

POSEY
Absolutely I can.

FAUSTINE
And you must remember for the jumbotron there's a whole section dedicated to radio piracy. Christian says they're the most likely to take it the wrong way. Or if I can be so bold, the right way.

POSEY
Yes, of course. Haha.

A couple of weavers look to Faustine. Faustine shakes her head at them, then swallows.

FAUSTINE
I think what we really want to know is where you were yesterday.

POSEY
Oh god yeah. Cause you won't believe this. Remember when I was talking yesterday and I saw a gleam out the window.

RHYS
I remember when you wore a hat in the middle of waxing inspirational, if that's your gleam.

Posey gently rocks the drooping cable connecting her laptop to the socket.

POSEY
Well I followed it yesterday to a lighthouse around the way, I mean you just can't see this thing as it is except from here. It is just insane, like a proper waterwheel right in its side. I sat down for tea with the keeper.

Posey looks up.

POSEY
We talked about things...

Posey can't quite see the interest she was expecting in everyone's faces.

POSEY
Um. We talked about making a website for the lighthouse. It's actually a match made in heaven when you think about it.

Posey cringes.

RHYS
(of gentle approval)
Jam sandwich, Posey.

INT. NET LOFT - NIGHT

With everyone gone home for the evening, Posey tips out the glass from the pan onto the table. She glues the shards of glass to two dome lampshades combined to make a sphere.

Then later with the lights turned off, flashes from the lighthouse periodically illuminate the disco-ball-lampshade hanging around the dangling light fixture, and in turn scenes in the Net Loft:

First, Posey looking at blueprints of Woolly Ness Lighthouse.

Then, Posey sketching a rough website plan, in a shape that resembles the tower of the lighthouse.

Finally, Posey writing Lorum Ipsum dummy text from memory into the text boxes on a computer screen.

EXT. WOOLY NESS - DAY

Palomar opens the door. Posey has a flip chart under her arm and a smile on her face. She gives the doorbell a superfluous ring.

POSEY
Oh how the wedding bell chimes.
(indicating between them)
There's something here.

PALOMAR
I have a boyfriend.

POSEY
No no no. Heheh. Just listen. You need to get the word out. I- You have a bunch of money.
(pointing at Palomar)
Lighthouse... Wait for it...
(herself)
...dot-com. Eh? It's actually stupid. That we didn't sign off on it yesterday, I mean.

Palomar walks inside.

PALOMAR
I'll spare you my ears if you can spare me your fingertips.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE BASEMENT — DAY

Palomar holds the flip chart, while Posey buttons up the back of her dress. She tries to peer round Palomar's large torso.

POSEY
And uh when you click on the beacon, it rotates and gives you a random new fact about the lighthouse. In twelve seconds, of course. Here, oof, go to the next one.

Palomar flips to the next page.

POSEY
So you see, you can easily book a tour because it has a whole calendar of dates.

Posey finishes buttoning. Palomar puts down the chart.

PALOMAR
Not a calendar of anything else.

POSEY
Well no.

PALOMAR
Thank you for the buttons, but it all seems very imaginary to

me.

POSEY
But it's right in front of you.

PALOMAR
Like magic and bubbles. Things that tend to go pop. Puff of smoke like.

POSEY
It isn't funny to keep bringing that up.

PALOMAR
Here, turn on the radio for me. 107.

Posey rolls her eyes and turns the dial. Out of the static, the syrupy voiced weather announcer WEATHER TODI.

WEATHER TODI (V.O)
Severe Gale Warning. Mainly high, occasionally very rough later in north. Squally showers.

POSEY
Squally showers? Like the punk group? What's this?

PALOMAR
The shipping forecast on Fair Station Daffodil. Every day, the whole coast and everyone afloat tunes into this pirate radio station. And then when it's over: thirty seconds of ad-time with a community focus. Now that's a public service. And in all honestly that's where my money's likely to go. And it's because I'm wrapped up in the affairs of real things like these. Things that wouldn't even show up on one of your screens, Posey-dot-com.

POSEY
(quietly)
The very real invisible waves that foretell the weather; Oh I share your outlook completely, I don't think.

Palomar grunts, stands, angrily changing the subject.

PALOMAR
Then how do I look?

POSEY
Severe.

PALOMAR
Good. That's just what I was going for.

She leaves. Posey looks down at Palomar's painted coat hook, and next to it a second: "Marco". RUNNING WATER from the other room. She leans back in her chair and looks plaintively out the window up to the tip of the aerial on the Net Loft. When Palomar comes back, Posey keeps looking out.

POSEY
If I look really closely, it's like there's a long string connecting my office and here. Sort of drooped from one to the other. I think maybe I unspooled it.

Palomar looks up at Posey as if for the first time, then out the window.

POSEY
Do you see it?

PALOMAR
That I don't.

INT. NET LOFT — NIGHT

Posey rushes into the dark Net Loft, putting down the flip chart she used as an umbrella. Rain patters against the window.

POSEY
Oh. Oh.

She opens a filing cabinet too quickly and it slides out, crashing onto the floor. She jumps, then moves the files to the table, spreading them out on top of the posterboard design for the lighthouse. She looks intently at the reports illuminated only by her computer screen. She rubs her eyes with her palms. Her glazed eyes suddenly focus on the disco ball.

POSEY
One. Two. Three. Four. Five. Six. Seven. Eight. Nine. Ten.
(panicked)
Eleven? TWELVE?

The room lights flick on. Posey starts, then straightens. Faustine stands by the lights, dry.

FAUSTINE
If you're looking at the copy for Hand Holdings, then I'm sorry to be the bearer of bad news.

POSEY
Oh no. It wasn't one of the rhinos, was it?

FAUSTINE
No, Posey they're going with someone else for their website and it's because you get them mixed up all the time. Like you are right now!

POSEY
That's really not good.
(eyes darting)
Well, let me work on the page for the Maritime Board. There's still the...

She clicks her fingers.

POSEY
Boundary shift! Right?

FAUSTINE
Yes, there is that. At twelve, Posey. You missed your chance, and it's too late for all this. Just go to sleep.

POSEY
TWELVE!

Posey jumps to the window.

FAUSTINE
Yes! The only people awake right now are the trawlers, pleasure cruisers and radio stations we were trying to reach with the stupid site anyway.

POSEY
Radio stations? What is this radio stations?

FAUSTINE
Pirate radio stations. I only said this yesterday to you. But I suppose that was out the other ear?

POSEY

Yes, but when you said that, that was a joke!

FAUSTINE
No, it wasn't. They broadcast offshore to get around- This whole thing was supposed to be a closing of the loophole-

Posey rushes to her briefcase, where she pulls out a little gadget she starts cranking violently.

POSEY
Oh my God, Faustine, a pirate radio station you're absolutely kidding me!

The radio in the gadget growls to life, first as static then soon a voice. Posey puts her ear up against the grill.

GUTTA-PERCHA (V.O.)
.. but unfortunately, my friends that time is now, for the sweet, sweet voice of your favourite, DJ Gutta-Percha, to leave your airwaves. The voyage is charted...

Posey turns with wide eyes to Faustine to speak then straight back to the radio.

POSEY
"Voyage charted"!

GUTTA-PERCHA (V.O.)
...and the engines are as stoked...

POSEY
"Engines stoked", Faustine!

GUTTA-PERCHA (V.O.)
...as the line-drawers at certain governmental body. Oh dear. With all hands on deck, I'll love you and leave you of course with the Manifesto Senz Parole, tonight by Sara Merck in 1977. Catch you on the B-side.

A disco instrumental starts playing.

POSEY
"The B-side"! The irony, Faustine!

Posey turns her eyes to the disco ball and squints,

raises and lowers her glasses. She runs at Faustine who backs against the wall, covering the light switch that Posey is eagerly trying to get at.

POSEY
We must turn the light off, quick! I can't see the disco ball.

FAUSTINE
Oh I'm not dancing right now. The light stays on till you get some rest.

POSEY
No! I'm a terrible boss. And what I've done to you this week is unforgivable. Turn the light off, I have to be sure.

Behind her, Faustine motionlessly turns off the light switch. Posey looks at the unilluminated disco ball.

FAUSTINE
What is going on?

POSEY
They're in huge trouble.

Posey points at the handheld radio.

FAUSTINE
Your piece of tat.

POSEY
No!

She points instead to out the window at the sea.

POSEY
That seaborne radio station, Daffodil or whatever. As long as I can't see that gleam, neither can they.

FAUSTINE
Your gleam, yes you said it was from the lighthouse! Oh, Posey!

Posey packs up her briefcase and heads to the door.

POSEY
Try to call in. Long-time listener, first-time rescuer sort of thing.

FAUSTINE
Where are you going?

POSEY
To get wrapped up in something real!

EXT. SHALLOW BUILDING ROOF — DAY

Posey hurries out of the Net Loft, bracing against the wind to hop off the foundation, which is now observably arrow-shaped and pointing in the direction she runs. Though not explained, the Net loft is an out-of-use airway beacon.

Stormy skies build up over the city.

EXT. WOOLLY NESS - NIGHT

Thunder and gales as Posey's car screeches on the gravel, and she hops out and towards the lighthouse. When approaching, she splashes through a small flow of water coming from underneath the door that ripples in the wind. She tries it, but its locked. Taking a step back, she sees that the wheel isn't turning. She looks up, spins around in agitation, and begins to climb the wheel. When at the top, she has to crawl into the space between the paddles to get under the low ceiling through the wall and into the lighthouse.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE - NIGHT

Water is splashing down onto the wheel but puddling up without turning it. Posey looks around and sees something lodging the wheel in place. Posey tugs and when it finally comes free, the wheel begins rotating again and Posey is pushed through the flow of water, where she rolls out dripping onto the ground.

She looks at what was wedging the wheel — a string-tied stack of the flyers from earlier. She heads upstairs in search of Palomar. She finds her asleep and sits down opposite her.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE - DAY

The next morning, Posey opens her eyes and finds herself alone. Exploring, she listens at the top of the stairs, where below, Palomar is talking to two representatives from the Fair Station Daffodyl. The dutybound PERRENIAL JOCKEYS have black braces and yellow mortarboard-berets.

CASS
We found this on the way up you know.
Some hats are supposed to stay on when you sleep.

Cass waves Palomar's beanie, then deposits it into her dungaree pouch.

NYRONE
When you sleep, when you mourn, when you drink, yes when you drink.

Nyrone pokes Palomar.

NYRONE (CONT'D)
If you'd been listening last night, which I know you do, and I know you weren't, you'd have heard the Manifesto Senz Parole and maybe been inspired to regain an echo of what you once had before it got too bad.

PALOMAR
I suppose you don't just mean last night then.

NYRONE
Oh of course not. And it takes a lot of good-will believing this wasn't a deliberate act from you to us. Nobody and I mean nobody wants us to have this conversation again.

CASS
Make sure to tune in for wear-a-band-t-shirt day.

They leave.

PALOMAR
You can come down.

POSEY
Sorry.

PALOMAR
Not at all.

POSEY
Hey those guys were actually terrifying. Need me to go beat them up for you?

Palomar laughs and then leads the way down to the basement.

PALOMAR
The PJs? They're small fish. Used to do my homework.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE BASEMENT - DAY

POSEY
By the way I happened to pick up this flyer. Yeah, in one of those racks in receptions. That or someone slid it under my waterwheel.

Palomar collapses into her armchair.

PALOMAR
Oh, not more.

POSEY
No, no. I'm not too late, am I? I know it says last week for the haunted tour, but I'm sure I saw a ghoul or two just now.

PALOMAR
Check again.

POSEY
Oh? Let me put my glasses on. You should know I'm not what I-

Posey looks again at the flyer.

POSEY
This is a lot older than last week. I'm sorry.

PALOMAR
Not at all.

Palomar sees the "Marco" coat hook, and scrunching up her face, gets out her chair to throw it out the window, with Posey furtively watching. Then, reminded by this action, Palomar pulls her beanie out her pouch. She turns it around in her large hands to find the seam and puts it on.

PALOMAR(CONT'D)
In fact I'm sorry. I think I forgot what I'm actually in charge of. Got wrapped in one thing, when maybe it should have been something different. Your very long string?

POSEY
That's a bit too kinky for me Palomar.

PALOMAR
Or maybe I'll run away with the money and become a hermit.

POSEY
No, I- If you're saying what I think you're saying I'll happily be your rebound website. I can put you in contact with all my people. But you've just reminded me that I have to call a friend. Talk soon?

PALOMAR
Soon.

Posey stops at the basement stairs and wags a finger at them.

POSEY
But now I need to know: what's 213? That's how many steps he carved with that tray-plaque, right? I thought it was only 193 but I never counted these.

PALOMAR
A Quaker's dozen.

EXT. LIGHTHOUSE GALLERY - DAY

Far below the lighthouse, a small fan-powered boat is docked at a jetty, where the two Perennial Jockeys load it with supplies. Up in the gallery, Posey, on the phone, opens and closes her fingers on her free hand in front of the beacon.

POSEY
Look at the wall, Faustine. I want you to guess what animal it is.

FAUSTINE (V.O.)
Never leave us in the dark like that again! I'm serious if you'll excuse the expression. Anything could have happened last night.

POSEY
It's a rhino. Too soon? Look I'm fine. Day saved. You can relax.

FAUSTINE (V.O.)
Day not at all saved, actually. We lost one of our three clients.

POSEY
Look at me making animals - did I not say? The lighthouse deal

went through! So we gained one of our three clients too.

FAUSTINE (V.O.)
Oh and a lot of stress on our part to save some ship I'm still not sure even exists.

POSEY
Without putting too fine a point on it, I am looking right at these weird-ass radio pirates with my own two eyes. And if you had two golden blots burned in your vision like I do, you would certainly not be doubting their existence. You're only too lucky I was there to do the day saving, or the deep-sea divers would have a new favourite station.

FAUSTINE (V.O.)
Well I couldn't find their number anywhere online so that would have been on them alone.

POSEY
These guys are old school. I meant check the yellow pages or something. Not everything has a-

Something strikes Posey. She turns back to look at the Shallow Building. Her eyes coast the horizon like they did the other night, and she heads down the 113 steps.

INT. LIGHTHOUSE - DAY

POSEY
You'll have to do it without me, but I know you can.

FAUSTINE (V.O.)
Hang on what's going on?

Posey passes the square windows.

POSEY
Woolly Ness Lighthouse, and the Maritime Board, and Palmprint. You and the weavers are so great when I'm not bungling things.

As Posey reaches the ground floor, Palomar comes up the other way from the basement. She throws Posey her briefcase.

POSEY
(Mouthing)
Thank you.

EXT. WOOLLY NESS - DAY

POSEY
This is my out-of-office memo. There's something here. Door-to-door. Outreach. I think I can make it work. I-
Bye.

FAUSTINE (V.O.)
Posey wait-

Posey hangs up then crouch walks. While the Perennial Jockeys have their backs turned, she slides around the fans and under the tarp with her phone in one hand and briefcase in the other. Just before they hop on, she covers the tarp over herself.

EXT. FLIPPING CHANNEL - DAY

As the Perennial Jockey's boat heads out to sea, Posey looks back towards the lighthouse and city as they grow smaller.